

PT-01

MVP Feature Set

A build-freeze recommendation for the thinnest credible MVP: narrow enough to ship with discipline, real enough to transact, demonstrate, and operate.

STRATEGIC ANCHOR

Simplex-ity should launch with a super-thin, commerce-capable MVP that proves trusted discovery, clean transaction flow, controlled creator-guided merchandising, and disciplined launch operations without dragging future-state platform complexity into the first release.

DOCUMENT INTENT

This document freezes the MVP feature boundary for build planning. It converts approved launch direction into a practical decision tool for product, engineering, and operators by defining what must be built now, what can remain manual, and what stays explicitly out of scope.

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SECTION 01

1. Executive recommendation

Simplex-ity should freeze MVP as a super-thin, commerce-capable, creator-guided retail surface with just enough operational scaffolding to launch credibly and be demonstrated confidently. The build should prove five things only: shoppers can discover products through familiar beauty navigation and creator context; products can be found through credible search and retrieval; cart and checkout complete reliably; the internal team can update high-change surfaces through a deliberately narrow CMS layer; and the platform can be deployed and operated through controlled environments rather than direct-to-production improvisation.

Decision statement

Approve an MVP centered on category, brand, search, creator, and product discovery; standard cart and checkout flow; Saved and basic account capability; visible trust and service surfaces; a minimum CMS control layer for high-change content; basic creator attribution; Google Analytics plus essential event tracking; and explicit DevOps and launch-readiness controls. Defer virtual try-on, Learn, guided collections, bundles, retailer-led edits, creator storefronts, loyalty, subscriptions, advanced data analysis, advanced SEO-growth tooling, search-as-a-service beyond the initial quality bar, advanced helpdesk, and self-serve partner tooling.

What this document does: It converts the approved launch direction into a hard feature boundary for build planning. It is deliberately broader than UI pages alone and narrower than phase 1 ambition. It includes content governance, creator operating logic, search quality, lean measurement, and launch controls, but it does not allow those needs to become an excuse for a broad editorial stack, a heavy analytics program, or speculative platform tooling.

Must-have	Should-have	Later / out of scope
35 capabilities	8 capabilities	15+ deferred areas

SECTION 02

2. Scope principles

- Transactable before expansive: any feature that does not directly help the platform launch, transact, or be governed should face a high bar for inclusion.
- Credibility before novelty: the launch should feel real to shoppers, brands, and investors through coherence, trust signals, and working operations, not through speculative technology.
- Manual-first where acceptable: launch should rely on existing commerce admin, a minimum CMS control layer, and lightweight operator tools before building custom admin software, self-serve partner tooling, or broad editorial workflow.

- Creator-guided, not creator-platform: creators should strengthen discovery and confidence, but the MVP should not behave like a network of storefronts or a parallel marketplace.
- Trust close to the decision point: authenticity, shipping, returns, relevance, and use guidance should appear where purchase decisions are made.
- Future-aware but not future-loaded: architecture should avoid dead ends, but future optionality does not justify present complexity.
- Search quality before search sophistication: search must work credibly in MVP, but heavyweight search platforms, deep personalization, and SEO-growth tooling should wait.

Working assumptions used to freeze the MVP

Area	Locked position	Why it matters
Primary market	United States only for MVP execution	Keeps launch logic, logistics, and compliance narrow.
Category scope	Makeup-led, with selected routine-support skincare only	Preserves the wedge without drifting into catalog sprawl.
Operating model	Curated first-party retail with controlled assortment and content governance	Supports trust, merchandising control, and cleaner operations.
Creator role	Managed affiliate and education layer, not storefront owners	Keeps creators valuable without importing platform complexity.
Virtual try-on posture	Explicitly out of MVP until vendor evaluation and QA gates are passed	Prevents beauty-tech ambition from distorting launch scope.
Working journey model	Category, brand, search, or creator entry -> PDP -> Saved or Cart -> Checkout -> basic account and service follow-up	Separate journey-map work has not yet been completed, so MVP planning uses this inferred path.
Operating posture	Manual-heavy, with disciplined use of Shopify, CMS, and lightweight spreadsheets or trackers where needed	Allows credible operations without building unnecessary back-office software.
CMS posture	Included only as a minimum content control layer for homepage, creator pages, creator edits, trust pages, and limited shareable modules	Preserves agility and partner-readiness without creating a broad editorial program.
Measurement posture	Google Analytics plus essential event tracking only; no broader analytics estate or SEO program in MVP	Keeps learning visibility without infrastructure creep.

SECTION 03

3. What the MVP must prove

Proof areas the launch build should support

Proof area	What must be true	Indicative evidence
Commercial proof	A shopper can move from discovery to completed order with enough confidence to buy.	Browse to PDP progression; add-to-cart rate; checkout completion; first orders placed without intervention.
Trust proof	The site looks and behaves like a legitimate premium retail surface rather than a concept demo.	Clear authenticity cues; visible service policies; coherent brand and creator presentation; low confusion in testing.
Operating proof	The internal team can publish, update, fulfil, support, and reconcile using lightweight controlled workflows.	No critical workflow blocked by missing admin tools; manual exception handling remains manageable.
Partner proof	Brands, creators, and investors can see the logic of the operating model from the product and supporting workflows.	Creator pages are governed; catalog feels curated; platform shows credible infrastructure rather than brochureware.

SECTION 04

4. Frozen MVP feature set

The tables below freeze the thinnest credible launch set. “Mode” clarifies whether the capability should be productised, handled manually, or delivered through a hybrid of lightweight build plus disciplined manual operation. This iteration also tightens the content layer, raises the search bar, and keeps measurement deliberately lean.

4.1 Customer storefront and discovery

Priority	Capability	Mode	Why it belongs in MVP
Must-have	Homepage	Built	Explain the proposition quickly, route shoppers into high-confidence browse paths, and surface trust and creator proof without introducing extra discovery systems.
Must-have	Shop landing route hub	Built	Provide a clean commerce entry point even if navigation remains tightly focused.

Must-have	Makeup category and subcategory pages	Built	Anchor the launch wedge in familiar beauty language and product-type browse.
Must-have	Skincare category and subcategory pages	Built	Support basket building and repeat potential while keeping the assortment tightly bounded.
Must-have	Brands directory and brand pages	Built	Support known-intent shopping and partner credibility.
Must-have	Bestsellers page	Built + Manual	Give new visitors a confidence-led route; curation can be managed manually at launch.
Must-have	Creators index	Built	Make creator-led discovery visible without overpowering the retail spine.
Must-have	Creator profile pages	Built + Manual	Translate creator credibility into relevance, use context, and shoppable confidence.
Must-have	Creator edit pages	Built + Manual	Create the only curated-discovery bridge required in MVP; content selection can remain internally managed.
Must-have	Search results with credible product, brand, and creator retrieval	Built	Resolve direct intent credibly from anywhere in the site shell; search quality is a launch requirement, not a cosmetic add-on.
Must-have	Product detail page	Built	Carry the trust, relevance, use, and purchase decision burden for the platform.
Must-have	Saved	Built	Make the site behave like a real retail surface and support comparison or deferred purchase.
Must-have	Cart	Built	Confirm basket contents cleanly and restate trust before checkout.

Must-have	Checkout	Built	Enable standard purchase completion with clear shipping, payment, and policy expectations.
Must-have	Basic account with order visibility and saved-item access	Built	Support return visits and make the platform feel operationally credible from day one.

4.2 Commerce and transaction engine

Priority	Capability	Mode	Why it belongs in MVP
Must-have	Catalog, variant, and pricing management in the commerce core	Built	A working store needs a clean source of truth for products, variants, pricing, and availability.
Must-have	Basic promotion and code handling	Built	Required for launch offers, creator-linked codes, and controlled campaign activity.
Must-have	US payment and shipping configuration	Built	Core transaction capability cannot be deferred or simulated.
Must-have	Order confirmation and basic notification flow	Built	Customers need explicit confirmation that a purchase succeeded.
Must-have	Basic stock visibility on sellable products	Built + Manual	Shoppers should not buy obviously unavailable items; manual stock updates are acceptable at launch.
Must-have	Order review, refund, and exception handling	Manual-first	The workflow must exist from day one even if it runs through standard admin tools rather than custom internal software.

4.3 Trust and service layer

Priority	Capability	Mode	Why it belongs in MVP
Must-have	About, Shipping & Returns, FAQ, Contact / Support, and policy pages	Built + Manual	Trust and service clarity are launch requirements, not footer filler.

Must-have	Trust blocks on homepage, PDP, cart, and checkout	Built	Trust must appear where hesitation happens, not only in utility pages.
Must-have	Authenticity, claims, and service wording governance	Manual-first	High-risk copy must be reviewed and managed intentionally even in a thin MVP.
Must-have	Support contact route and basic response workflow	Built + Manual	Customers need a clear help path before and after purchase.

4.4 Content, creator, and operator controls

Priority	Capability	Mode	Why it belongs in MVP
Must-have	CMS-managed homepage, creator pages, creator edits, trust pages, and limited shareable modules	Built	The team needs a minimum control layer for high-change surfaces, not a broad editorial estate.
Must-have	Internal content approval and publishing control	Built + Manual	Creator and trust content should not go live without review, even if approvals are handled lightly.
Must-have	Product content update workflow	Manual-first	Operators must be able to correct imagery, copy, and merchandising details quickly.
Must-have	Creator content intake and onboarding workflow	Manual-first	A controlled intake path is required even before any self-serve tooling exists.
Must-have	Creator attribution setup using links, codes, or referral identifiers	Built + Manual	Creators are part of the launch story, so attribution logic must be real even if reporting remains simple.
Must-have	Manual payout reconciliation and audit trail	Manual-first	Trust with creators depends more on clarity and accuracy than on automation in phase 1.
Must-have	Basic internal access roles	Built	Content and operations require minimum permission boundaries, even in a very thin operating model.

4.5 Measurement and launch controls

Priority	Capability	Mode	Why it belongs in MVP
Must-have	Google Analytics plus essential event tracking	Built	The platform must generate minimum usable learning from day one without dragging in a larger analytics stack.
Must-have	Source and creator attribution capture	Built	Traffic without source context weakens both learning and partner credibility.
Must-have	Basic DevOps, staging, deployment, and launch QA checklist	Built + Manual	A credible launch requires controlled environments, repeatable deployment, and testable flows, not direct-to-production improvisation.
Must-have	Manual reporting cadence for early performance review	Manual-first	Initial reporting can stay lightweight, but the review loop must exist before scale and should not depend on a broader BI layer.

SECTION 05

5. Should-have but non-blocking features

These items would improve usability or operator efficiency, but the MVP should not wait on them. They should only be pulled forward if effort is genuinely low and they do not reopen larger dependencies.

Features that may be added if effort is low

Priority	Capability	Why it is non-blocking
Should-have	Filter and sort refinement beyond the basic category spine	Improves browse control as SKU count grows, but the site can launch with a cleaner, simpler browse model.
Should-have	Advanced autocomplete and richer relevance controls beyond the initial quality bar	Useful for polish, but the MVP should first prove credible search retrieval and initial tuning rather than a broader search feature set.

Should-have	Email capture and lightweight lifecycle hooks	Helpful for follow-up and investor credibility, but not required to transact or demonstrate the core commerce loop.
Should-have	Enhanced account self-service	A lean account area is enough for launch; deeper self-service can follow once order volume justifies it.
Should-have	Basic internal dashboard layer beyond the manual review pack	Nice to have for speed, but a manual reporting pack remains acceptable during initial proof.
Should-have	Review-request collection flow	Useful after first fulfilled orders, but not a prerequisite for the first thin release.
Should-have	Support macros or lightweight helpdesk tooling	Operationally helpful, but early support can run through a managed inbox and scripted responses.
Should-have	Creator intake form with structured fields	Improves consistency, but manual intake is acceptable while the program remains small.

SECTION 06

6. Manual-first operating model for launch

The MVP should feel like a platform externally while remaining deliberately manual internally. The right question is not whether a workflow can be automated; it is whether automation is necessary before the business has proven demand, partner fit, and real operating friction.

Operational workflows that should remain intentionally light

Workflow	MVP handling	Why manual is acceptable now
Creator onboarding	Handled through internal brief, checklist, agreements, and manual review	Early creator volume should be small enough to manage without a portal.
Creator content publishing	Drafted or loaded into CMS by the internal team; approved before publish	Keeps quality and claims control tight while the workflow is still being proven.
Creator payout reconciliation	Tracked through codes, links, and a manual payout sheet	Accuracy matters more than automation at early scale.
Bestsellers and featured merchandising	Curated manually against agreed rules	No algorithm is needed before traffic and sales patterns are real.

Stock updates and low-stock handling	Managed through commerce admin plus manual exception checks	Protects against oversell without requiring custom inventory software.
Customer support triage	Run from shared inbox or lightweight helpdesk with prewritten responses	Launch volume should not justify a heavy support stack.
Claims, authenticity, and service wording review	Reviewed internally before publication or update	Trust risk is too important to automate loosely.
Performance review	Compiled in a weekly manual pack from analytics, commerce, and ops data	Initial learning volume does not require a mature BI layer.
Homepage, creator, and trust-page updates	Managed through narrow CMS models with internal publish control	Reduces engineering dependency on high-change surfaces without turning MVP into a broad editorial system.

SECTION 07

7. Explicitly out of scope for MVP

These items are not “deferred but quietly desirable.” They are out of MVP because they would widen the build, add new dependencies, or reintroduce future-state ambition before the thin slice has proven itself.

Deferred feature families and why they stay out

Priority	Deferred area	Rationale
Later	Virtual try-on	Explicitly excluded until a vendor passes evaluation and QA gates; it is not a launch dependency.
Later	Learn hub and guide-page system	Education should stay inside creator and commerce surfaces first.
Later	Guided collections by concern, ingredient, finish, routine stage, or use case	Useful later for SEO and richer discovery, but not required in the thinnest launch.
Later	Simplex-ity edits and bundle families	Retailer-led curation systems add merchandising weight before the creator-led bridge is fully tested.
Later	Creator storefronts	Would distort the MVP into a parallel creator platform.
Later	Creator CRM and advanced creator analytics	Not required to prove creator relevance or basic attribution.
Later	Self-serve brand dashboards or onboarding portals	Partner workflows should stay managed and manual until partner volume demands more.

Later	AI-led diagnostics, quizzes, and routine engines	Adds complexity before the basic discovery model is proven.
Later	Loyalty and rewards systems	Retention mechanics should follow after standard retail operations stabilize.
Later	Subscriptions or rigid recurring-order logic	Not required to prove the initial commerce loop.
Later	Advanced reviews and UGC display layer	Valuable once there is enough order volume to populate it credibly.
Later	Search-as-a-service beyond the initial quality bar, advanced personalization, and SEO-growth tooling	The MVP should prove clean navigation, credible retrieval, and a lean measurement posture first.
Later	Advanced helpdesk, returns automation, broader analytics, and operator dashboards	Premature internal tooling and analytics infrastructure would create more surface area than value.
Later	Marketplace or seller flows	Conflicts with the controlled retail posture.
Later	Multi-market launch support	The MVP should not absorb Canada or broader international complexity yet.

SECTION 08

8. Build implications for engineering and sprint planning

- Prefer configuration and managed tools over custom internal software whenever the workflow can run safely through Shopify, a deliberately narrow CMS layer, and lightweight operator trackers.
- Do not build self-serve creator or brand tooling into MVP. The operating model is managed, not platformized.
- Treat content governance, search quality, attribution, and exception handling as real launch requirements even when their execution remains manual-first.
- Keep the public surface narrow. Adding a new page family is acceptable only when it carries a clear commerce, trust, or operating burden that cannot be handled elsewhere.
- Keep analytics lean: retain Google Analytics and essential events, but do not let broader BI, SEO-growth instrumentation, or reporting architecture creep into the first release.
- Any proposed addition that introduces a new vendor, a new data model, or an ongoing workflow burden should be treated as a scope escalation, not a small enhancement.
- Treat DevOps as part of MVP substance, not technical background noise: staging, deployment discipline, and launch-readiness controls are part of what makes the platform credible.

Decision rules during backlog breakdown

Use this rule	Avoid this mistake
Admit the item only if it is required to transact, trust, operate, or demonstrate the platform credibly.	Reject the item if it exists mainly to make the MVP feel larger, smarter, or more future-facing.
Use manual workflows first when they can carry the load safely.	Do not build internal tooling simply because the eventual scaled workflow will need it.
Keep creator features inside the managed retail model.	Do not blur the line between creator-guided discovery and creator-owned storefront logic.
Keep learning measurable, but lean, from day one.	Do not postpone source attribution or minimum event capture in the name of moving faster, and do not use that need to justify a broad analytics stack.

SECTION 09

9. Approval lens and freeze rule

This scope should be treated as frozen once approved. A feature should only be pulled into MVP after the freeze if it meets at least one of the following tests: it removes a true transaction blocker; it resolves a material trust gap; it closes an operating failure that cannot be handled manually; or it is essential to a specific partner or investor demonstration already on the critical path.

Freeze rule

No feature should enter MVP simply because it is strategically attractive, common in mature commerce stacks, or useful in a future state. The burden of proof sits with the person asking to widen scope, especially if the request turns lean content control into a broad CMS estate or turns basic measurement into analytics sprawl.

Questions to use when change requests appear

Scope question	Approval lens
Does it change the public IA or add a new page family?	Escalate. It may reopen BX-03 decisions and should not be treated as a minor request.
Does it introduce a new vendor or materially widen an existing one?	Escalate. Vendor and architecture decisions should remain downstream of the frozen MVP set, and CMS or search requests are not “small” if they expand the operating model.
Does it increase recurring manual workload materially?	Escalate. Thin MVP does not mean hidden operational debt without an owner.
Does it behave like partner self-service, loyalty, or beauty-tech expansion?	Reject by default unless the business case changes materially.

Final recommendation

Simplex-ity should launch with a commerce-first, creator-guided, manual-supported MVP that is narrow enough to build quickly and real enough to carry commercial, partner, and investor conversations with confidence. The right launch is not the broadest one. It is the one that looks intentional, converts cleanly, and does not hide behind future-state complexity.